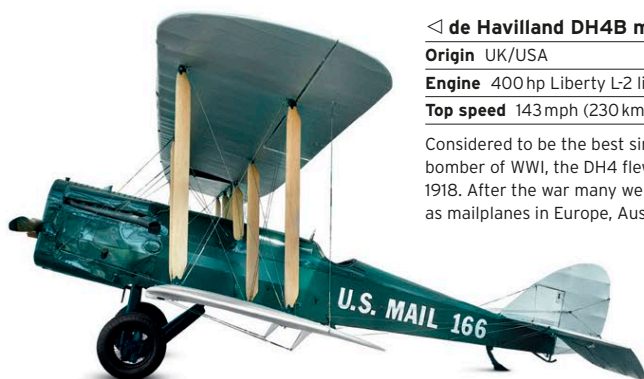


Mailplanes and Barnstormers

With thousands of trained pilots and surplus aircraft from the war available, aviation really began to gain momentum. Barnstorming pilots giving joyrides brought aviation to the general public's attention and Hollywood made flying films using any old planes it could find. Governments increasingly moved mail by air, which led to the production of dedicated mailplanes.



◁ de Havilland DH4B mailplane 1918

Origin UK/USA

Engine 400 hp Liberty L-2 liquid-cooled V8

Top speed 143 mph (230 km/h)

Considered to be the best single-engine British bomber of WWI, the DH4 flew with the US Army in 1918. After the war many were converted for use as mailplanes in Europe, Australia, and the US.



◁ Curtiss JN-4 Jenny 1920

Origin USA

Engine 90 hp Curtiss OX-5 liquid-cooled V8

Top speed 75 mph (120 km/h)

First introduced into the US Army in 1915 the Jenny was probably the most famous US aircraft of WWI. Thousands were sold as surplus when the war ended, some still in their packing cases, and for as little as \$50. The aircraft is considered to have played a pivotal role in the emergence of civil aviation in the US.



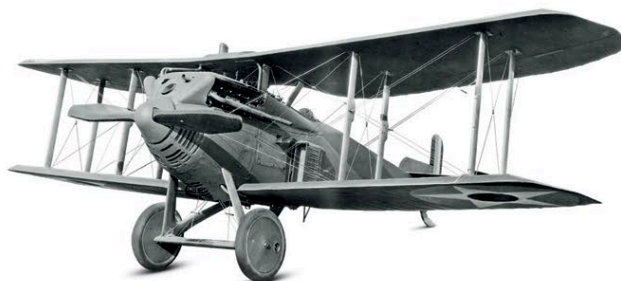
◁ Nieuport 28 C1 1926

Origin France

Engine 160 hp Gnome 9-N Monosoupape air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 122 mph (196 km/h)

Although not an especially successful fighter, the Nieuport 28's place in history is assured because it was the first fighter to be flown in combat by an American fighter squadron. Sold off to civilians in 1926, a small fleet of surplus 28s appeared in early Hollywood films, including *The Dawn Patrol*.



◁ Thomas-Morse MB-3 1920

Origin USA

Engine 300 hp Wright-Hisso liquid-cooled V8

Top speed 141 mph (228 km/h)

Built by both the Thomas-Morse Company and Boeing, the MB-3 entered service too late to see combat in WWI, and had a relatively short service life. At least one MB-3 was used in the classic aviation film *Wings*.



▷ Douglas M-2 1926

Origin USA

Engine 400 hp Liberty L-2 liquid-cooled V8

Top speed 140 mph (225 km/h)

When the US Post Office decided it could no longer rely on converted army-surplus DH4s to operate on the mail runs, it contracted Douglas to produce a dedicated mailplane.



△ Pitcairn Mailwing 1927

Origin USA

Engine 220 hp Wright J-5 Whirlwind air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 131 mph (211 km/h)

Another type that was specifically designed for the expanding US Air Mail system. Pitcairn produced over 100 Mailwings, with some being built as three-seat sportplanes. Howard Hughes is alleged to have owned one.



△ Boeing B-40 1927

Origin USA

Engine 420 hp Pratt & Whitney Wasp air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 128 mph (206 km/h)

Built to service the US Air Mail routes, the B-40 incorporated a small cabin, which allowed it to carry two passengers as well as the mail. The type was originally fitted with a liquid-cooled Liberty engine.

